

THE BEAUTY PARLOUR BUSINESS HAS ALWAYS BEEN BIG IN INDIA. NOW IT'S THE TURN OF SPAS.



HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com

IN FULL Bloom

From the survival of the fattest, it's now all about surface glitter as nose jobs and tummy tucks become as acceptable as fairness creams and hair colour

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- India is currently the largest market for fairness products, estimated at Rs 950 crore.
- Slimming clinics, skin clinics, a host of plastic surgeons, and for every minor wrinkle and crow's feet, there is an amazing array of choices available to us.

Cultural theorist N. Rajyalakshmi interviews artist Pushpamala N. on the quest for eternal youth, beauty and fitness, and the culture of consumption.

NR What do you think about the recent craze for plastic surgery in India?

PN I'm really shocked at how powerful the plastic surgery lobby seems to be. Some years ago, Agony Aunts in magazines advised people with acne, big noses or skinny and fat ones to use grandma remedies, exercise, or just change their hairstyles or clothes to hide the feature. It's straight-away nose jobs and tummy tucks and botox injections now. And I'm sorry to say that

our plastic surgeons being no artists, make all the noses the same, a Caucasian upturned Barbie doll nose, which you can see from Shilpa Shetty downward. I think a standard how-to manual comes along with the nose job kit, which the surgeons follow faithfully.

NR And the nose is one of the most individualised features.

PN Someone told me that the shape of the nose and the shape of the chin are related, so if you change one, you have to change the other. I think this was Michael Jackson's downfall. As he kept changing his nose, he had to keep changing his chin.

Which reminds me, fairness creams being big business here, all the *phoren* cosmetic companies are in the race for the huge market. East meets West, tradition meets modernity. Shah Rukh Khan, who started off being brown-skinned, is fair and lovely now, no doubt from using the men's fairness cream that he endorses.

NR But I see more people walking now in the cities. It's quite the fashionable thing to exercise.

PN Oh yes, the ideal of urban Indians in the past was the survival of the fattest—to let go as soon as you have your first child, let it all hang out from between your short blouse and the too-low sari waist—or have it all pop out extravagantly between the buttons of the too-tight safari shirt. It was a sign of prosperity and contentment. Men and women nowadays are buying sports shoes and going for brisk walks round and round the walking paths that have been created in all the former playgrounds of our cities. They are usually of Japanese-type design, and have artificial rocks created from gravel and Fevicol between picturesquely low rolling mounds of Chinese grass. I saw a very funny Kannada TV talk show where the 'thin' male anchor is telling the fat ladies that if they don't lose weight their men will fly away and then there's a sort of montage of large women jogging and puffing juxtaposed with rows of beauty contestants walking the ramp. Talk about sexism.

NR And what do you think about the beauty contests?

PN Years ago, when ABCL was hosting the first Miss World contest in India in Bangalore, a motley crowd of protesters landed up from all over India, extreme right rubbing shoulders with the left wing, femi-